

Preaching History

Paper Read at the SBL International Meeting, St Andrews, 6th–11th July 2013 by Matthias Jendrek, Paderborn/Bochum/Mainz

1. Introduction

If the title of this paper seems ambiguous, this is good. Because it is meant to be. “Preaching history” refers either to the action of preaching by using history – or to history starting to preach all by itself. To say it in advance: Both interpretations are right.

This paper is an excerpt of current work on my doctoral thesis. In general, I have structured the thoughts I want to present today in two parts: The first part is a summary of the work done on 1 Chronicles 16:8–36 that forms the basis of the thesis I want to propose. The second part turns to phenomena called ‘abbreviations’ and unrecorded prayers. I have to give you a definition of what I mean by them. Then I’m going to show where they occur in Chronicles, and how they work or function. There are parallels between the structures 1 Chronicles 16 and the chapters containing abbreviations or unrecorded prayers. Out of these parallels, I’m going to draw a conclusion with regard to the function of poetic or rhetoric passages within narrative contexts in Chronicles.

I’m afraid I’ve got to say two sentences concerning method in advance. I make use of a very basic model of intertextuality. Texts point to other texts by certain signals, called “hypertexts” – similar to hyperlinks on the internet. The texts pointed to are “hypotexts”. Knowledge of the hypotexts a passage presupposes gives hints to the ideal reader of the passage, who has to know the hypotexts also. “Readers” in this case does not mean an actual human being, but a “model” reconstructed with the help of the rhetorical devices.

2. Paraenetic Implications of 1 Chronicles 16

The psalm verses in 1 Chronicles 16:8–36 have long been recognised as paradigm for Israel’s worship. However, the text shows many features, which give the chapter several capabilities of meaning.¹ This pluriformity of meaning is important. A summary of the features supporting this pluriformity reads like this:

1. 1 Chronicles 16:8–36 uses psalm texts. The alterations to the psalm texts used clarify the imperative meaning: Non-fitting verb forms have been changed to imperatives. For example, the perfect third person singular masculine of זכר in Psalm 105:8 ‘He is mindful of his covenant for ever’², has been altered to ‘(do) remember his covenant for ever’ in 1 Chronicles 16:15. This is imperative second person masculine plural, then.

¹ Comprehensive lists of those meanings can be found in the studies of James W. Watts, *Psalm and story. Inset hymns in Hebrew narrative* (JSOT.S 139. Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1992); Carmen Diller, “Der Kompositpsalm 1 Chr 16,8-36 als theologisches Kompendium.” in *Wer darf hinaufsteigen zum Berg JHWHs? Beiträge zu Prophetie und Poesie des Alten Testaments*. Festschrift für Sigurdur Örn Steingrímsson zum 70. Geburtstag (ed. H. Irsigler and K. Ólason; ATSAT 72; St. Ottilien: EOS, 2002).

² As long as not explicitly stated otherwise, all quotations of Bible texts follow the translation of the NRSV ACE, that is: National Council of Churches, ed. *The Holy Bible. Containing the Old and New Testaments* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995).

2. The imperatives in verses 8–13 take up the verbs of 1 Chronicles 16:4. This purports that verses 8–36 can be read as fulfilment of David's order to remember (זכר), thank (ידה) and praise (הלל) God.
3. 1 Chronicles 16:41 repeats line 34, הודו ליהוה כי טוב כי לעולם חסדו. This includes the imperative הודו again and this transports the imperative character of the poetic passage to the narrative context. The line and the imperative are taken out of the poetic passage and are implemented in the narration.
4. The meaning of the last poetic verse 1 Chronicles 16:36b is ambiguous: It could be translated either as "Then all the people said 'Amen!' and praised the Lord" as the New Revised Standard Version renders it, or as "Then all the people said 'Amen!' and 'Praise the Lord!'" The latter is a suggestion of Mark Throntveit.³ The translation 'the people said ה'לל ליהוה' <[w^e=]hallēl la=YHWH> or: the interpretation of ה'לל ליהוה as spoken language, suggests that the people of the text took up the words given in verses 8–36. Regardless of the historicity of this, one capability of meaning is that 1 Chronicles 16:8–36 provides a paradigm for the praise of God.

1 Chronicles 16 has three theological core topics. A) Israel really *is* God's chosen people. Correspondingly, B), foreign nations are inferior. C) The true ruler of Israel, then, is God himself; he is Israel's saviour with attributes as might, strength and splendour.⁴ The psalms used in 1 Chronicles 16 feed these topics. John Kleinig describes these contents as "proclamation of the Lord's sovereign presence".⁵ This is the most concise summary of functions and contents of 1 Chronicles 16 I found.

1 Chronicles 16 does indeed proclaim by meeting the reader in his familiar surroundings, for example by quoting well-known psalms. The verses take their reader along back in history, to the transfer of the Ark and the cult of David.⁶ Thus, they form identity within their readership. At the same time, they call on the reader to perform the cultic actions via the imperatives. Moreover, the verses provide a template for the asked performance. Thus, while "re-enacting"⁷ the narration, the reader gets involved by and through remembrance.

The imperative sense added to the narrative by means of a poetic passage works on different levels of speech. Within the world of the text, it turns to the audience of Asaph and his fellow Levites. Above this text level, it turns to the (model) reader. The original addressees of the psalms and of the inner structures of the texts (Jacob, the tribes and the likes of them) contribute to the pluriformity of meaning.⁸

³ Mark A. Throntveit, "Songs in a new key. The psalmic structure of the Chronicler's hymn (1 Chr 16:8–36)." in *A God so near. Essays on Old Testament theology in honor of Patrick D. Miller* (ed. B. A. Strawn; Winona Lake: Eisenbrauns, 2003), 159.

⁴ Cf. Diller, *Kompositpsalm*, 191–98.

⁵ John W. Kleinig, *The Lord's song. The basis, function and significance of choral music in Chronicles* (JSOT.S 156. Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1993), 147.

⁶ Cf. Kirsten Nielsen, "Whose song of praise? Reflections on the purpose of the Psalm in 1 Chronicles 16." in *The Chronicler as author. Studies in text and texture* (ed. M. P. Graham; JSOT.S 263; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1999), 336; Diller, *Kompositpsalm*, 190–91.

⁷ Tamara C. Eskenazi, "A literary approach to Chronicles' ark narrative in 1 Chronicles 13–16." in *Fortunate the eyes that see. Essays in honor of David Noel Freedman in celebration of his seventieth birthday* (ed. A. B. Beck et al; Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1995), 269.

⁸ Cf. Diller, *Kompositpsalm*, 183–84.

The line 1 Chronicles 16:41 anchors the poetic passage in the narration, by repetition of line 34. Other occurrences of the verse do the same; they anchor hypotexts like 1 Chronicles 16 in narrative contexts. They are “abbreviations”.

3. Functions of Abbreviations and *Unrecorded Payers*

a) Abbreviations

The term ‘abbreviation’ refers to shortened repetitions of texts that are assumed to be known to readers. This is a pragmatic definition of “abbreviation”.⁹ Chronicles features two, possibly three sentences, serving as abbreviation: One is the nominal clause צדיק יהוה, ‘YHWH is just’ (1 Chronicles 12:6); tentatively, I mention the formula ברוך יהוה. — The second certain sentence is הודו ליהוה כי טוב, sometimes with the middle part טוב כי omitted. This quotation occurs six times in Chronicles, two times in 1 Chronicles 16, three times in 2 Chronicles 5 and 7 and in 2 Chronicles 20. It stems from the psalms. Psalms 106(:1); 107(1); 118(1–4.29) and, of course, 136, make use of it.

Within Chronicles, 2 Chronicles 5 and 7 belong to the narrative of the dedication of the temple by Solomon. The abbreviations frame the “dedication prayer”, and 2 Chronicles 7:3 gives a people’s response to heavenly fire alighting the altar, as it happened on Mount Sinai (Leviticus 9:24). As Sara Japhet puts it: The people show “*their profound experience of and absolute trust in God’s presence*”¹⁰ – “God’s presence” is the important bit here, one of the meanings of 1 Chronicles 16.

All the more interesting is 2 Chronicles 20:21, where the cultic context of the abbreviation is not as obvious. The situation of the narrative is a military campaign of Moabites and Ammonites against the southern kingdom under rule of Jehoshaphat. The story 2 Chronicles 20:1–30 embeds not only the said abbreviation, but also one of the royal prayers of Chronicles, a prophecy and two *unrecorded prayers*. The abbreviation occurs precisely at the turning point of the narration. 2 Chronicles 20:22, which is the verse following the abbreviation, says that YHWH started to act at the same moment (וַיִּבְעַת הַחִלּוֹ בְּרִנָּה וְתִהְיֶה $\hat{u}=v^e\acute{e}t\ h\acute{e}h\acute{e}ll\acute{u}$ $v^e=rinn\acute{a}h\ \hat{u}=t^ehill\acute{a}h$), as ‘singers’ started to sing הודו ליהוה כי לעולם חסדו. Even as the verse does not clearly state that the song caused YHWH to act, there is undoubtedly a connection between the abbreviation and God’s action.¹¹ It is impossible to leave out the thanks and praise. To find out about its purpose, I ask whether it is a hypertext.

Of course it is neither possible to state that Jehoshaphat and his people indeed sung “thanks to the Lord, for he is good” in a historical perspective; nor is it possible to claim found hypotexts to be necessary or exclusive. It is feasible to check whether connections are possible, and to get an idea whether they are probable. As the verse הודו ליהוה כי לעולם חסדו is not frequent in the Hebrew Bible, only five texts present themselves as hypotexts: The said psalms 106, 107, 118 and 136; and 1 Chronicles 16. As I am concerned with a (model) reader of *Chronicles*, I start to check 1 Chronicles 16. Coming from the beginning of Chronicles, it is possible to view

⁹ Thomas Hieke, “Neue Horizonte. Biblische Auslegung als Weg zu ungewöhnlichen Perspektiven,” *ZNT* 6 (2003): 69, 71.

¹⁰ Sara Japhet, *I & II Chronicles. A commentary* (OTL. Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 1993), 610.

¹¹ Cf. Kleinig, *Lord’s song*, 178.

2 Chronicles 20:21 as a quotation of 1 Chronicles 16:34.41. Thus it reminds the reader of this earlier text.

One of the capabilities of 1 Chronicles 16 has been to proclaim f YHWHs powerful presence and his ability to save Israel – and these are exactly the qualities needed in course of the narrative of 2 Chronicles 20.¹² This renders the entire story of Jehoshaphat and the Ammonites and Moabites as an example for remembering and confessing God at the right moment. However, the other capabilities of 1 Chronicles 16 add more to the text than this rather “cultic” power. The abbreviation – including an imperative – actively calls on its (model) reader, and it calls on him to act according to the example given in the narration: Trust in God, let him squash the enemies. This coincides with the contents of 1 Chronicles 16, too; “foreign nations are inferior”.

The observation of John Kleinig that 1 Chronicles 16 and 2 Chronicles 20 are climax of their respective narrative arches (Ark narrative in 1 Chronicles, Asa and Jehoshaphat in 2 Chronicles 20) makes another case for 1 Chronicles 16 as intertext of 2 Chronicles 20.¹³ Additionally, it strikes that 2 Chronicles 20:21 introduces the Levites as acting *לְהַדְרֵת־קֹדֶשׁ*, “in holy adornment”; a term found only in Ps 29:2; 96:9 – and, once again, 1 Chronicles 16:29.¹⁴

The abbreviation 2 Chronicles 20:21 connects Jehoshaphat’s story to 1 Chronicles 16. Two phenomena less investigated, but probably the more interesting, reinforce this. They are the

b) Unrecorded Prayers

The term ‘unrecorded prayer’ refers to *verba dicendi*, which signal that in course of the narrative, someone uttered a prayer, that is: directed words to YHWH – but the text of the prayer is not set down. Thus, ‘unrecorded prayer’ in first place is simply the counterpart to a ‘recorded prayer’, as Samuel Balentine¹⁵ calls the prayer texts given in Chronicles.

2 Chronicles 20 features two of these signals. The first *unrecorded prayer*, 2 Chronicles 20:19, is indicated by הלל Pi’el; the other indicator in 2 Chronicles 20:26 is בָּרַךְ Pi’el. To determine the functions, it is worth to have a look on the actors: Subject of הלל Pi’el are the Levites, in 1 Chronicles 16:4 as well as in 2 Chronicles 20 – and, additionally, in 2 Chronicles 29:30, where mention of the “words of David and Asaph the seer” makes the connection to 1 Chronicles 16 explicit. There, 1 Chronicles 16, it is David who ordered Asaph to “remember (זָכַר), thank (יָדָה) and praise (הֵלֵל)” God.

Frank Crüsemann has been one of the first to recognise relationship between the verses 2 Chronicles 20:19.21.26.¹⁶ With the Levites and the signal word הלל, a possible connection to 1 Chronicles 16 (and, once again, to the Psalms) is still visible, while possibly less compelling than in case of the abbreviations. Here another functional mode for hypertexts comes into play: Structural similarities or patterns. Sara Japhet proposes a certain sequence of events

¹² Kleinig, *Lord's song*, 147.

¹³ In case of 2 Chronicles 20, cf. Kleinig, *Lord's song*, 173.

¹⁴ Cf. Kleinig, *Lord's song*, 176, note 2.

¹⁵ Cf. Samuel E. Balentine, “You can't pray a lie. Truth and fiction in the prayers of Chronicles.” in *The Chronicler as historian* (ed. M. P. Graham, K. G. Hoglund and S. L. McKenzie; JSOT.S 238; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1997), 251.

¹⁶ Cf. Frank Crüsemann, *Studien zur Formgeschichte von Hymnus und Danklied in Israel* (WMANT 32. Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener, 1969), 205, note 1.

re-occurring several times within narratives in Chronicles, where I want to add one extra element:

Human idea or cause for an action —

asking/seeking YHWH (this is my addition) —

divine help —

successful accomplishment —

and thanksgiving.¹⁷

If Crüsemann is right and there is a functional connection between the unrecorded prayer in verse 19 and the abbreviation in verse 21, this would include the “proclamatory” power of 1 Chronicles 16. This would form the element of “divine action” in the proposed sequence of events.

Subjects of בָּרַךְ Pi’el in 2 Chronicles 20:26 are most probably ‘Jehoshaphat and his people’ of verse 25. This at least includes the king in the praise. בָּרַךְ Pi’el concludes 1 Chronicles 16:8–36 (line 36), and occurs in the vicinity: 1 Chronicles 16:2.43 – the latter concluding the chapter and the narrative arch. Now the blessing of YHWH in 2 Chronicles 20 also forms the end of the narration; in the sequence of events, this would be “thanksgiving”. Jehoshaphat and his people had to fight the Moabites and Ammonites: Human action. After asking YHWH for help which resulted in a prophecy by Jahasiël (2 Chronicles 20:15–16), Jehoshaphat and his men did not even have to fight – they started their day with the Levites praising YHWH (the first *unrecorded prayer*). Their fortune changed with the singers starting הוֹדוּ לַיהוָה (the abbreviation), and all ends with the blessing of YHWH (this is the second *unrecorded prayer*). At the latest one might come across the connection of the final blessing to 1 Chronicles 16 by reading one of the following verses, 2 Chronicles 20:28: “They came to Jerusalem, with harps and lyres and trumpets, to the house of YHWH.” The Ark arrived at Jerusalem with similar accompaniment.

The abbreviation “thanks to the Lord” brings the imperatives to the reader into the narrative of Jehoshaphat. Two unrecorded prayers reinforce this, like constantly reminding a reader of the same topics. Parallels in the situation of a king ordering song, closeness in expressions and a consistent trend to include the (model) reader in the actions cumulate to the impression that 2 Chronicles 20 shares some key capabilities of 1 Chronicles 16. Both narrations have exemplary character and try to involve readers, directing orders to them to join worship of YHWH.

4. Conclusion

To make this clear, once again: I do not claim that Jehoshaphat and Israel did *indeed* sing or use 1 Chronicles 16:8–36, in a historical perspective. In fact, using the same song thrice in one day may even seem rather boring. What I want to stress is that the *unrecorded prayers* work in the same way as 1 Chronicles 16 that truly becomes the *pattern* it has been already recognised as. In turn, chapter 16 brings its specific programme to the reader’s mind – no less than three times in the one narrative of Jehoshaphat. *Unrecorded prayers* (and abbreviations as well) are significant hints to how a reader can imagine the proceedings of a narration, and they establish connections between narrated events, the text itself and (later) readers.

¹⁷ Cf. Sara Japhet, *1 Chronik* (HThK AT. Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 2002), 303.

1 Chronicles 16 is but one example for immanent hypotexts in Chronicles. There are the other royal prayers, which show intertextual links between each other as well as paraenetic capabilities. This is what I'm actually working at in my doctoral thesis, entitled 'Poetry in Chronicles'. 'Poetry', of course, refers to the fact that all the recorded prayer texts show a distinct literary shaping. They may not be 'poetic' in a strict sense – in fact, most scholars flatly declare them 'prose' – but still, they disturb and break the flow of the surrounding narrative passages. If abbreviations and *unrecorded prayers* then more or less constantly remind a reader of the same topics and themes, stemming ultimately from psalms, one is allowed to state that there *is* Poetry in Chronicles, and that it is worth to investigate about Poetry *of* Chronicles. The first result of this work is that 'poetry in chronicles' serves as a means to include some addressees not named in the text itself, and to transport a paraenetic meaning. Thus, not only the spoken passages of Chronicles, that is: The prayers, prophecies and speeches, are a kind of 'sermon'; but the entire narrative of the books of Chronicles gets rather more than a mere touch of preaching. It turns into proclamation; Chronicles preaches utilizing history; and history told that way starts preaching 'out of itself'. Thus, the title of this paper obviously is ambiguous: It refers to history that preaches, as well as to the action of preaching, using history.

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